Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 22-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
- © 2026 Bill Wetzel - Licensed under CC BY 4.0 https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/

1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` in space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣` `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
.  – any character
*  – zero or more
+  – one or more
?  – zero or one / lazy match
^  – start of line / negation in class
$  – end of line
(  ) – capture group
[  ] – character class
{  } – repetition count
|    – alternation
\    – escape character itself
```

1.4 Launching

- `helix`
- `helix <file>`
- `helix <file1> <file2> … <file1>`
- `helix <directory>`
- `helix -help`
- `hx in some distributions or by alias`

1.5 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

```
v3wd – enter select mode, select 3 words,
       delete
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
u / U – undo / redo change in linear
        history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree
                history
:ear / :lat – move backward / forward in
              history by step count or time
              span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
<nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
:wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and
             quit
:wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
:q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
:o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
:w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
:hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal
             split
:vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical
             split
␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s)
      in horizontal split
␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s)
      in vertical split
gf – open/create file(s) under selection,
     open url under selection.
␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace
     root
␣F – open file picker at current working
     directory
␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
<enter> – open selected in current view
Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
:n – create new scratch buffer
:bc – close current buffer
:bca – close all buffers
:bco – close all but current buffer
:bn – next buffer
␣b – open buffer picker
ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
gn – go to next buffer
gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
␣ws / ␣wv – split horizontal / vertical, current
            buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new
              buffer
␣wq – close current split
␣wo – close all but current split
␣ww – next split
␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down /
            right
␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up /
            down / right
␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with a `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
zz, zc – align to center
zt – align to top
zb – align to bottom
zm – align to middle horizontally
zj – scroll down
zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
:tutor – open tutorial
␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
gh, g| – beginning of line
<nn>g| – column <nn>
gl – end of line
gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
ge – bottom of file
gw – two-char labels on words, label
     to go to word
g. – to last modification in current
     file
gj – down textual line
gk – up textual line
gs – first non-white-space char
gt – top of screen
gc – middle of screen
gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation
]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change
Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax
        tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in
        syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
% – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor
        at end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
;     – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the
                  object indicated by <ch> below:
w / W – word / WORD
p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc. – specified surround pairs
m – closest surround pair
f – function
t – type or class
a – argument/parameter
c – comment
T – test
g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
x – current line, extend by line
X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
]p – to next paragraph
[p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax
        node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax
        tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax
        tree
Alt-a – select all siblng nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax
        tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
Alt-.        – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v – toggle select mode
Esc – return to normal
)   – cycle primary selection forward
(   – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
S – split on match
Alt-s – split on newlines
C / Alt-C – add selection below / above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
& – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
,           – remove all except primary
              selection
Alt-,       – remove primary selection
( / )       – rotate primary backwards /
              forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward /
                forward
K – keep selections matching the
    regex
Alt-K – remove selections matching the
        regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
i – before selection
a – after selection
I – at start of line
A – at end of line
o – add line and insert below cursor
O – add line and insert above cursor
Esc – end insert (return to normal)
.   – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ – newline below
[␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
c – selection -> yank buf, change
    selection
Alt-c – change, no save
=     – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) containing selection
< – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
~ – change case
` – set lowercase
Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
␣C – Toggle block comment
␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
J – join lines in a selection
Alt-J – join lines inside selection and
        select the inserted space
<under> – trim whitespace from
          selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>,
                  default 80
:sort – sort ranges in selection
:format – format file using external
          formatter / language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
y – selection -> yank buf
p – paste yank buf after the cursor
P – paste yank buf before the cursor
␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
␣Y – yank main selection -> system
     clipboard
␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before
          selection(s)
␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
R – replace selection with yank buf
" – select register to yank to or paste
    from
```

2.8 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
n, N – next, previous match
* – search for current selection, respect
    word boundaries
Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm – go to matching delim
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
!     – insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
$     – keep selection(s) where command
        returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under
     cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol
     under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace
                         config file
:config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace
     folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
Ctrl-s – commit undo
         checkpoint
Ctrl-x – autocomplete
Ctrl-r – insert a register
         content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous
                     word
Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
Ctrl-u – delete to start of
         line
Ctrl-k – delete to end of
         line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-
<bksp> – delete previous
         char
Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line

<Up>, <Down>, <Left>,
<Right>, <PageUp>,
<PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
– usual meaning
  but discouraged
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
<enter> – open selected
<tab> – select next completion
        item
<backtab> – select previous
            completion item
Alt-b – backward a word
Ctrl-b – backward a char
Alt-f – forward a word
Ctrl-f – forward a char
Ctrl-e – to prompt end
Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc
         cursor (may be changed
         to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p – select previous history
Ctrl-n – select next history
Ctrl-r – insert the content of the
         register selected by
         following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
<Home> – to first entry
<End> – to last entry
Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
<enter> – open selected
Alt-<enter> – open selected in
              the background
              without closing
              the picker
Ctrl-s – open horizontally
Ctrl-v – open vertically
Ctrl-t – toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
<enter> – close menu and accept
          completion
Ctrl-c – close menu and reject
         completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```